

Circumcision:

A Critical Issue of Human Rights

by

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All human beings have a sacred right to the inviolable privacy of their own bodies. Circumcision of infants and young children violates that right.

Throughout history societies have taken the attitude that babies and children are not people with human rights, but assets and chattels, to be loved or exploited, nurtured or abused, as whim, fashion, tradition, or religion dictate. The truth is babies are people with human rights. In an age of slowly dawning enlightenment, societies are now just beginning to understand this. With this understanding routine infant circumcision must come to an end.

All human beings must have the freedom to choose for themselves whether they want to have their normal healthy foreskins or any other normal healthy body parts amputated for any reason.

Circumcision is medically unnecessary elective surgery. Millions of people, over 80% of the world's population in fact, live their lives happily whole and intact (not circumcised). Most of these have few if any foreskin problems, which is absolute proof that infant circumcision is unnecessary surgery.

Most doctors, nurses, midwives, and medical institutions worldwide, particularly in the socially and medically progressive Scandinavian and other western European countries, recognize that circumcision of infants is neither necessary nor desirable.

Only in the United States is there still debate about medical or health benefits

resulting from circumcision. This debate exists only because the habit of circumcising newborn infants is so rigidly established that stopping is too embarrassing, and the operation is too lucrative for doctors to want to stop. Every argument, true or false, valid or invalid, about medical or health benefits from circumcision is irrelevant and illegitimate.

Any unnecessary elective surgery performed on any person incapable of giving informed consent violates human rights to free choice, no matter what benefits may be thought to result. Circumcision of newborn infants or very young children of either sex is unnecessary surgery. Babies and very young children cannot give informed consent. Therefore infant circumcision violates fundamental human rights.

The surgical removal of a healthy bodily part from any individual without fully informed consent of the individual is a violation of medical ethics. Normally, a doctor who is caught amputating healthy body parts without consent from the patient is prosecuted, except in the case of infant foreskins.

Therefore it is time for the medical profession in the United States to learn that foreskins are normal functional parts of the body. It is time to start prosecuting doctors who circumcise and parents who request circumcision.

Religion cannot be allowed as an excuse to permanently mark a child with a surgical amputation of a healthy body part